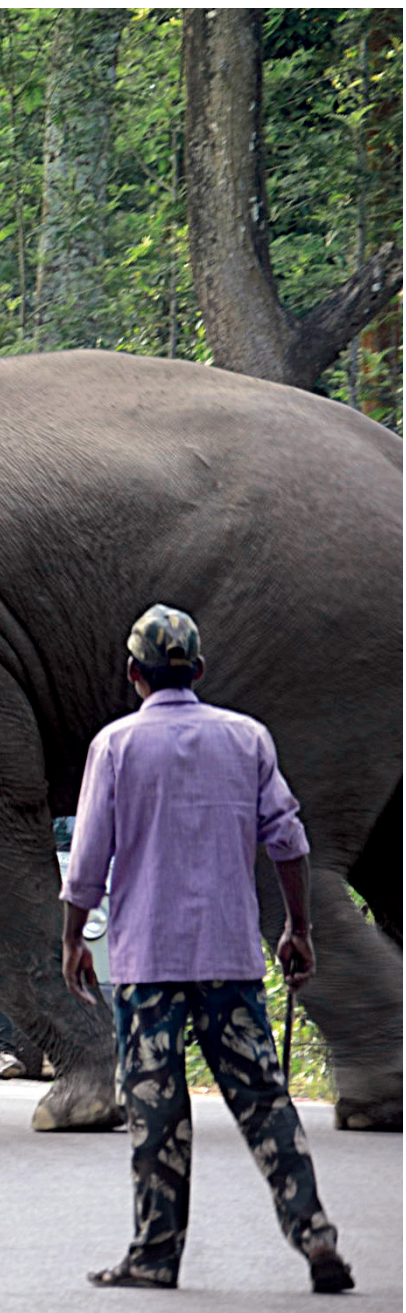
It

is almost nine on an early January morning, and the day has begun in earnest in Sakleshpur, a town located at the edge of the Western Ghats in Karnataka's Hassan district. Sachin Gowda, a planter, is getting his 10-year-old son ready for school. It's the land of coffee—in the front yard of Gowda's estate home laid out to dry in the winter sun are coffee berries from the first pickings of the season, which will stretch till February. Soon, the plants will blossom and clothe the undulating terrain in a sea of white, stringy flowers. By now, the picking of berries should have been in full swing. But Gowda has given the day off to his workers, fearing for their safety. A herd of 26 elephants has moved into the plot abutting his house—for the umpteenth time in the past three years. The manager of a neighbouring estate momentarily drops by to enquire whether the elephants have crossed over. "Leave me a message when they have moved, brother. I have workers in my field," he says. Since morning, most neighbours in the vicinity of Kirehalli, where the matriarch, locally known as Beetamma, and her herd are camping, have asked the same of Gowda.



NATURE CONSERVATION FOUNDATION

When the pachyderms first came to this part of Sakleshpur taluk years ago, the residents venerated their footprints with a 'puja'. Elephants hadn't been spotted in Kirehalli village in about 30 years. Their arrival, thus, was a fortuitous occasion brought about by the Covid-19 pandemic that ground the traffic on the busy Hassan-Mangaluru highway to a halt, which let herds from the reserve forests in the south cross the road and venture out towards new pastures. The landscape around Kirehalli, interspersed with coffee plantations and agricultural fields, proved to be a fine camping ground for the elephants. And so, rather than heading back into the forests, they stayed on, moving from estate to estate, feeding on the paddy, millets, banana and jackfruit. "Now, we pray for them to leave," says Gowda.

Per latest government data, there are about 65 resident elephants in Hassan alone. There have been 17 human deaths since 2019-20 in chance encounters, while 8,382 crop damage claims amounting to Rs 5 crore were paid out between 2019 and 2022. The issue reached the Karnataka assembly in September last year after hassled residents turned their ire on local legislators. The government in December 2022 agreed to capture and shift all the elephants. Last year, four task forces were set up in the Hassan, Chikkamagaluru, Kodagu and Mysuru districts, all of which form some part of the Mysore Elephant Reserve, home to most of Karnataka's 6,000-odd elephants.

IN A TIGHT SPOT

Hassan faces a unique problem. Wedged between the plantation districts of Chikkamagaluru and Kodagu, it isn't the only district dealing with resident elephants. But it has only 12 per cent of its area—880 sq. km—under forest cover; the other two districts have thrice as much. Thus, there simply isn't enough land in Hassan to where the elephants can be driven back. "It's basically the coffee estates where they have been thriving," says Kumar Pushkar, the additional principal chief conservator of forests (wildlife).

The district had faced a similar situation a decade ago, following which a panel of ecologists was set up to study the situation. Between 2013 and 2015, as many as 22 elephants were relocated in what was among the biggest captures of wild elephants in the country back then. But newer herds moved in, and their numbers grew. Over the years, foresters in Karnataka have tried various methods to deter the elephants from leaving the forests: they dug elephant-proof trenches, put up solar fences, and made barricades from discarded steel rails. None of these methods was tenable, for they don't cover large contiguous stretches and thus are useful only up to a point. In fact, conservationists argue that these steps have worsened the problem—elephants began entering human habitations and using roads only when solar fences at plantations blocked their path or trail, thus leading them to come into direct contact with people.

Warning systems have now come up in Hassan. One can frequently find red beacons aglow around Kirehalli to indicate the presence of elephants, and forest department jeeps that use loudspeakers